JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category : Cyber Safety & Digital Security

Module 9 - Reporting Cyber Crime

Module Overview

This handbook is your complete, beginner-to-advanced guide to **Reporting Cyber Crime** — where to report, how to collect and preserve evidence, and which helplines to call in India. Every other module in this category teaches you how to avoid becoming a victim; this module teaches you exactly what to do the moment prevention fails, because speed and the right first steps make the biggest difference to whether your money or justice can still be recovered.

By the end of this module, you will not need to search anywhere else to know exactly who to contact and what to do after any cyber incident.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Identify the correct portal, helpline, or authority for any type of cyber incident
- Understand the difference between a portal complaint, an FIR, and a Zero FIR
- Collect and preserve digital evidence correctly before it's lost
- Act within the "golden hour" to maximise the chance of recovering stolen funds
- Know India's key cybercrime and related helplines by heart
- Support family members or others through the reporting process confidently

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Why This Topic Matters

Cybersecurity incidents in India surged from about 10.29 lakh in 2022 to 22.68 lakh in 2024 — a rise of roughly 120% in just two years. Yet between April 2021 and September 2025, only around **6.7% of the ₹3,588 crore** defrauded from citizens was ever recovered.

> *Reality Check: Reporting financial fraud within the first hour dramatically increases the chance that banks and the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal's fund-freezing system can stop stolen money before it disappears across multiple accounts.*

Knowing how to report — quickly, correctly, and with the right evidence — is not a footnote to cyber safety. It is often the single factor that decides whether a victim gets their money back at all.

Introduction

India's cybercrime reporting ecosystem has several parts working together:

- **National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (NCRP):** cybercrime.gov.in, the primary online complaint system for all cybercrime types

- **1930 Helpline:** The dedicated 24×7 toll-free number for financial fraud, directly triggering bank-side fund freezes
- **Local Cyber Crime Police Station:** Where portal complaints can be escalated into formal FIRs
- **Sector-Specific Channels:** Including banking ombudsman routes, SEBI for investment fraud, the Data Protection Board for data breaches, and Sanchar Saathi for lost/stolen phones
- **Dedicated Helplines:** Including 1098 (CHILDLINE) and 181 (Women's Helpline) for specific vulnerable-group concerns

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Fundamental Concepts

Complaint vs FIR vs Zero FIR

Term	Meaning
Portal Complaint	A registered report on cybercrime.gov.in — acknowledged, but not itself an FIR
FIR (First Information Report)	A formal police document that begins a criminal investigation
Zero FIR	An FIR that can be registered at any police station regardless of jurisdiction, later transferred to the correct one
e-Zero FIR	An automatic Zero FIR triggered for large financial-fraud complaints (above ₹10 lakh) made via NCRP/1930, introduced by I4C in May 2025

The Golden Hour

The first hour after discovering financial fraud is often called the **"golden hour"** — the window during which banks and NCRP's fund-tracking system have the best chance of freezing stolen money before it moves through multiple accounts and becomes unrecoverable.

CFCFRMS

The **Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System (CFCFRMS)** is the part of the NCRP portal specifically used by police, banks, and payment providers to trace and freeze the flow of stolen funds after a financial-fraud complaint is filed.

Complete Detailed Explanation

Part A — Where to Report

Situation	Where to Report
Financial/UPI/banking fraud	Call **1930** immediately, then file on cybercrime.gov.in
Any other cybercrime (fake websites, hacking, fraud)	cybercrime.gov.in → "Report Other Cyber Crime"
Crimes against women or children (harassment, exploitation, abuse)	cybercrime.gov.in → "Report Women/Child Related Crime," or call **1098** (child) / **181** (women)
Lost or stolen mobile phone	Sanchar Saathi portal (sancharsaathi.gov.in) — block/trace via CEIR
Personal data breach by a company/ app	Data Protection Board of India, under the DPDP Act, 2023
Investment/stockbroker fraud	Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) complaint channels
Unresolved banking service complaint	RBI's Integrated Ombudsman Scheme
Serious or high-value fraud needing an FIR	Nearest Cyber Crime Police Station — complaints can be filed at any station regardless of where the crime occurred, since cybercrime has nationwide jurisdiction under the IT Act

Part B — Evidence Collection

What to collect immediately:

- Screenshots with visible device timestamps of messages, calls, or transactions
- Transaction IDs, UPI reference numbers, and bank statement entries
- The exact URL of any fake website or fraudulent page
- Screen recordings for dynamic content (Stories, live streams, disappearing messages)
- Suspect details: phone number, UPI ID, email, username, or social media handle

How to preserve it correctly:

- Do not delete the original messages, emails, or app conversations
- Avoid editing or "cleaning up" screenshots — keep them exactly as captured
- Note down the date, time, and platform for every piece of evidence
- Back up evidence to a separate device or cloud storage in case your device is later needed for forensic examination

Part C — Helplines (Quick Reference)

Helpline	Purpose
1930	National Cyber Crime Helpline — financial fraud, 24×7, toll-free
1098	CHILDLINE — child-related cyber abuse/exploitation
181	Women's Helpline — online harassment, stalking
112	National Emergency Number — for any immediate danger

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
NCRP	National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (cybercrime.gov.in)
CFCFRMS	The fund-tracing and freezing system used after a financial-fraud complaint
Zero FIR	An FIR registrable at any police station, transferred to the right one later
Golden Hour	The first hour after fraud, offering the best chance of freezing stolen funds
I4C	Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre, under the Ministry of Home Affairs
CEIR	Central Equipment Identity Register, used to block/trace stolen phones
Data Protection Board of India	The regulator handling complaints under the DPDP Act, 2023

Step-by-Step Understanding

What to Do in the Golden Hour (Financial Fraud)

1. Call **1930** immediately to request a fund freeze
2. Simultaneously call your bank's official helpline to block the account/card
3. File a detailed complaint on cybercrime.gov.in under the financial fraud category
4. Note down transaction IDs, timestamps, and any suspect details
5. Follow up with your bank in writing within 3 working days to protect zero-liability provisions

How to File a Complaint on cybercrime.gov.in

1. Go directly to **www.cybercrime.gov.in** (verify the genuine .gov.in domain)
2. Register using your mobile number and email ID, verified by OTP
3. Choose the correct category — financial fraud, women/child-related, or other cybercrime
4. Fill in incident details and upload your collected evidence

5. Submit and note the acknowledgement number (a 14-digit number starting with "2," sent via SMS)
6. Track your complaint status through your portal dashboard

Real-Life Indian Examples

(Widely reported public patterns, described for educational awareness.)

- **e-Zero FIR Initiative (2025):** Introduced by I4C in May 2025, this mechanism automatically registers a Zero FIR for financial-fraud complaints above ₹10 lakh made through NCRP or 1930, speeding up formal investigation for high-value cases.
- **Fund-Freeze Success Stories:** Victims who called 1930 within minutes of a fraudulent UPI transaction have, in numerous reported cases, had part or all of the stolen amount frozen before it could be withdrawn.
- **Delayed Reporting Losses:** Cases reported days or weeks after a fraud occurred have shown dramatically lower fund-recovery rates, reinforcing why speed is emphasised so strongly.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario 1: You notice an unauthorised ₹15,000 UPI debit from your account just minutes ago.
Call 1930 immediately, then your bank, then file a detailed complaint on cybercrime.gov.in the same day.

Scenario 2: Your teenager is receiving threatening messages from an anonymous account.
File a complaint under "Report Women/Child Related Crime" on cybercrime.gov.in, or call 1098, and preserve all messages as evidence first.

Scenario 3: Your phone was stolen while travelling.
Report it on the Sanchar Saathi portal to block the device using its IMEI number, in addition to filing a police complaint.

Scenario 4: You suspect a mobile app has leaked your personal data in a breach.
File a complaint with the Data Protection Board of India under the DPDP Act, alongside reporting to the app's own grievance officer.

Government Rules / Guidelines

- **Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA):** Operates the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal and the 1930 helpline through the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C).
- **I4C:** Coordinates the e-Zero FIR mechanism, CFCFRMS fund-freezing system, and national-level cybercrime data collection.
- **RBI:** Operates the Integrated Ombudsman Scheme for unresolved banking service complaints and sets liability rules for unauthorised electronic transactions.
- **SEBI:** Handles complaints related to investment and stockbroker fraud.

Laws & Policies

Law / Provision	What It Covers
RBI Master Direction on Limited Liability of Customers in Unauthorised Electronic Banking Transactions, 2017	Provides zero customer liability if unauthorised transactions are reported within 3 working days, and limited liability for delayed reporting
Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023	Provides for Zero FIR registration at any police station, and includes provisions enabling electronic notices to banks/intermediaries to freeze fraudulently obtained funds
IT Act, 2000 — Section 43	Civil liability for unauthorised access or damage to computer systems, relevant to evidence and claims in cybercrime cases
Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023	Provides the complaint route to the Data Protection Board of India for personal data breaches

Important Statistics

Metric	Figure
Cybercrime incidents in India (2022 → 2024)	10.29 lakh → 22.68 lakh (about 120% increase)
Reported cyber fraud losses (2024)	Approximately ₹22,845 crore
Total defrauded amount (April 2021 – September 2025)	Approximately ₹3,588 crore
Amount recovered of that total	Approximately ₹239 crore (about 6.7%)
Investment-scam share of losses	Approximately ₹17,400 crore
e-Zero FIR threshold (introduced May 2025)	Financial fraud complaints above ₹10 lakh
Zero-liability reporting window for unauthorised transactions	Within 3 working days

(Figures are approximate, drawn from Ministry of Home Affairs, I4C, and RBI data reported through 2025–2026.)

Best Practices

- Call 1930 within the first hour of discovering any financial fraud
- File a detailed complaint on cybercrime.gov.in the same day, with all available evidence
- Notify your bank in writing within 3 working days to preserve zero-liability protection
- Preserve screenshots, transaction IDs, and URLs exactly as captured, without editing
- Note the acknowledgement number from every complaint you file

• Escalate to your nearest cyber crime police station for an FIR if losses are significant or unresolved

Common Mistakes

• Waiting days before reporting financial fraud, losing the "golden hour" advantage
• Deleting messages or "cleaning up" evidence before reporting
• Assuming a portal complaint alone is the same as filing an FIR
• Not following up in writing with the bank within the required timeframe
• Not noting down the complaint acknowledgement number for tracking
• Feeling embarrassed and staying silent instead of reporting promptly

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Filing a complaint on cybercrime.gov.in is the same as filing an FIR"	A portal complaint is an acknowledged report, not an FIR — serious cases may still need a formal FIR at a police station
"I can only report a cybercrime at a police station in the city where it happened"	Cybercrime has nationwide jurisdiction — complaints can be filed at any cyber crime cell
"There's no point reporting fraud if a few hours have already passed"	While speed matters greatly, reporting quickly at any point still gives investigators a chance to act
"Banks won't help unless I file a police complaint first"	Reporting through 1930/NCRP directly triggers a fund-freeze request, independent of a formal FIR
"Only large financial losses are worth reporting"	All cybercrimes, regardless of amount, contribute to broader investigations and should be reported

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Call 1930 within the first hour of financial fraud	Don't wait or hesitate before reporting
File a detailed complaint on cybercrime.gov.in with evidence	Don't rely on a verbal complaint alone
Preserve evidence exactly as captured	Don't delete or edit screenshots/messages
Notify your bank in writing within 3 working days	Don't skip written follow-up with your bank
Escalate to a cyber crime police station for serious cases	Don't assume the portal complaint alone resolves everything

Safety Tips

For Financial Fraud
- Save your bank's official helpline number and 1930 in your phone contacts
- Screenshot transaction alerts and confirmations immediately
- Follow up with your bank in writing, not just by phone

For Harassment or Abuse Cases
- Preserve all messages/content before blocking anyone
- Use the "Report Women/Child Related Crime" category for sensitive cases
- Involve a trusted adult or authority for cases involving minors

For Families
- Ensure every family member knows the 1930 helpline number
- Practice basic evidence-preservation habits together (screenshotting, not deleting)
- Encourage prompt reporting rather than embarrassment or silence

For Ongoing Cases
- Track your complaint status regularly through the portal dashboard
- Keep copies of every acknowledgement number and correspondence
- Escalate to a cyber crime police station if the matter remains unresolved

Practical Checklist

- ☐ Saved the 1930 helpline and my bank's official number in my phone
- ☐ Know the difference between a portal complaint, an FIR, and a Zero FIR
- ☐ Know how to screenshot and preserve evidence correctly
- ☐ Know which NCRP category applies to different types of cybercrime
- ☐ Aware of the 3-working-day window for zero-liability bank reporting
- ☐ Know the Sanchar Saathi portal for lost/stolen phones
- ☐ Shared this reporting knowledge with my family

Quick Revision Notes

- Report financial fraud via 1930 immediately, then cybercrime.gov.in the same day
- A portal complaint is not an FIR — serious cases need police station escalation
- The "golden hour" is the critical first-hour window for fund-freezing success
- Preserve evidence (screenshots, URLs, transaction IDs) without editing or deleting
- Zero liability for unauthorised transactions applies if reported within 3 working days

- Different situations have different channels: 1930 (financial), 1098 (child), 181 (women), Sanchar Saathi (lost phone), Data Protection Board (data breach)

Key Takeaways

1. Speed matters more than almost anything else in cybercrime recovery
2. Knowing the right channel for your specific situation saves critical time
3. Evidence preserved carefully and promptly strengthens any case significantly
4. A portal complaint and a formal FIR are different things — know when you need both
5. There's no shame in reporting — silence only helps the people who defrauded you

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Glossary

- **CEIR** — Central Equipment Identity Register, used to block/trace stolen phones
- **CFCFRMS** — Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System
- **FIR** — First Information Report, the formal document starting a police investigation
- **Golden Hour** — The critical first hour after fraud for maximum fund-freeze chance
- **I4C** — Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre
- **NCRP** — National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (cybercrime.gov.in)
- **Zero FIR** — An FIR registrable at any police station regardless of jurisdiction

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Frequently Asked Questions

1. What number should I call for financial cyber fraud in India?
1930, the National Cyber Crime Helpline, available 24×7 toll-free.

2. Is filing a complaint on cybercrime.gov.in the same as filing an FIR?
No — it's an acknowledged complaint; serious cases may still require a formal FIR at a police station.

3. What is the "golden hour" in cybercrime reporting?
The first hour after discovering fraud, offering the best chance banks/NCRP can freeze stolen funds.

4. What is a Zero FIR?
An FIR that can be registered at any police station, later transferred to the correct jurisdiction.

5. What is CFCFRMS?
The system used by police, banks, and payment providers to trace and freeze fraudulently transferred funds.

6. How do I report crimes against women or children online?
Use the "Report Women/Child Related Crime" category on cybercrime.gov.in, or call 1098 (child) or 181 (women).

7. What evidence should I collect after a cyber incident?
Screenshots with timestamps, transaction IDs, URLs, screen recordings, and suspect contact details.

8. Should I delete abusive messages after reading them?
No — preserve them exactly as received before blocking or reporting.

9. What happens if I report unauthorised bank transactions within 3 working days?
You may be eligible for zero liability under RBI's rules, provided the fault wasn't yours.

10. Can I file a cybercrime complaint at any police station, regardless of where the crime occurred?
Yes — cybercrime has nationwide jurisdiction under the IT Act.

11. What is the e-Zero FIR initiative?
An I4C mechanism (introduced May 2025) automatically registering a Zero FIR for financial-fraud complaints above ₹10 lakh made via NCRP/1930.

12. Where do I report a lost or stolen phone?
Sanchar Saathi (sancharsaathi.gov.in), which can block/trace the device via its IMEI number.

13. Where do I complain about a personal data breach by an app or company?
With the Data Protection Board of India, under the DPDP Act, 2023.

14. What should I do if my bank doesn't resolve my complaint?
Escalate to RBI's Integrated Ombudsman Scheme.

15. Where do I report investment or stockbroker fraud?
Through SEBI's official complaint channels.

16. What acknowledgement do I get after filing an NCRP complaint?
A 14-digit acknowledgement number, sent via SMS, used to track your complaint.

17. Is it worth reporting a cybercrime if some time has already passed?
Yes — while speed maximises recovery chances, reporting at any point still supports investigation.

18. What is I4C?
The Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre, under the Ministry of Home Affairs, coordinating national cybercrime response.

19. Should I contact my bank before or after filing an NCRP complaint?
Both, and as simultaneously as possible — call your bank and 1930 right away, then file the detailed complaint.

20. Can family members help someone who's a victim of cybercrime?
Yes — helping preserve evidence and make the initial report quickly can make a real difference.

21. What is the national emergency number for any immediate danger?
112.

22. Do all cybercrime cases eventually need a formal FIR?
Not always — many financial fraud cases are resolved at the complaint/fund-freeze stage, but serious or high-value cases typically require one.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Illustrations

(For JanGyan design team — placement suggestions only; no images generated here)

- **"Golden Hour" countdown visual** → within "Fundamental Concepts"
- **Flowchart: "Which Helpline/Portal Do I Use?"** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part A"
- **Evidence-collection checklist visual card** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part B"

- **Helpline quick-reference card (1930/1098/181/112)** → near "Practical Checklist"
- **Complaint vs FIR vs Zero FIR comparison diagram** → within "Fundamental Concepts"

Official References

- Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) — National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal citizen manuals
- Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) — e-Zero FIR initiative and CFCFRMS documentation
- Reserve Bank of India — Master Direction on Limited Liability of Customers in Unauthorised Electronic Banking Transactions, 2017
- Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023
- Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 — Data Protection Board of India
- Department of Telecommunications — Sanchar Saathi portal documentation

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Official Government Website Links

- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal: **https://cybercrime.gov.in**
- Sanchar Saathi (lost/stolen phones): **https://sancharsaathi.gov.in**
- Reserve Bank of India: **https://www.rbi.org.in**
- SEBI: **https://www.sebi.gov.in**
- CERT-In: **https://www.cert-in.org.in**
- MeitY: **https://www.meity.gov.in**

Key Helplines: Cybercrime (Financial Fraud): **1930** | CHILDLINE: **1098** | Women's Helpline: **181** | Emergency: **112**

Conclusion

Every module in this category has taught you how to avoid becoming a victim of cybercrime — but no system is perfect, and knowing exactly what to do the moment something goes wrong is just as important as prevention itself. A quick call to 1930, a same-day complaint on cybercrime.gov.in, carefully preserved evidence, and the right follow-up with your bank can be the difference between a full recovery and a permanent loss.

This is the final module in your Cyber Safety journey with JanGyan — but the habit it teaches matters for life: **act fast, report correctly, and never stay silent.**

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Module 9 of the Cyber Safety & Digital Security Category